

“I SHALL BE AN **AUTOCRAT**, THAT'S MY **TRADE**; AND THE GOOD LORD WILL **FORGIVE ME**, THAT'S HIS.”

Attributed to **Catherine the Great**, Empress of Russia

RUSSIA SAW THE ARRIVAL OF TWO RULERS over the course of 1762, first with the ascension of **Peter III** (1728–62) and later **Catherine II** (1729–96), who became known as Catherine the Great. When Peter III became emperor, he made clear his support of Prussia in the Seven Years' War and then pulled Russia out of the conflict. His views were deeply unpopular with ministers and the public. A conspiracy against him was quickly organized, leading to his arrest. His wife, Catherine, was installed as empress of Russia. Peter III was imprisoned, where he died in dubious circumstances. Catherine the Great's reign was marked by **Russian aggression and territorial expansion**. She introduced wide-ranging reforms in agriculture, industry, and education. She also relaxed Russia's censorship laws and was known for her love of literature and particular fondness for French philosophers and writers—including Voltaire, with whom she corresponded for 15 years.

As the Seven Years' War continued, **Spain** became further drawn into events as the British occupied its key Caribbean port of Havana. In addition to this, Britain was able to use troops in India to occupy Manila, in the Philippines, which was also a Spanish colony. At the same time, **Spain and France** entered a secret agreement known as the **Treaty of Fontainebleau**. Under the terms of the treaty, Spain received France's Louisiana territory in



Catherine the Great

The German-born empress of Russia, who reigned from 1762 until 1796, oversaw the territorial expansion of her adopted country.

North America, which stretched west of the Mississippi River. The treaty was partly to thank Spanish Bourbons for their support of French forces, and also to get rid of a potential drain on resources. Spain also benefited from the deal because it would block British expansion toward Spanish territory, especially nearby Mexico.

In France, the philosopher and writer **Jean-Jacques Rousseau** (1712–78) published his influential treatise, *The Social Contract* (*Du Contrat Social*) in which he examined the relationship between governments and the governed, and the question of freedom in the face of political authority. It was immediately banned by French authorities.



A print of a fireworks display in London celebrating the Peace of Paris, which ended the Seven Years' War.

OUT OF MONEY AND EXHAUSTED, THE EUROPEAN POWERS fighting the Seven Years' War brought the conflict to a close with the Treaty of Paris (also known as the Peace of Paris) and the Treaty of Hubertusburg. The cost had been enormous—the lives of hundreds of thousands of soldiers, and mountains of money. Britain's national debt rose from £75 million to £133 million; Prussia raised taxes and debased the taler three times. For Austria it cost 392 million gulden (the original estimate was 28 million) and French national debt rose from 1,360 million livres in 1753 to 2,350 million livres in 1764.

The **Treaty of Paris** involved Britain, France, and Spain. The French faced the largest losses: they ceded to Britain their territories in present-day Canada, with the exception of the islands of St. Pierre and Miquelon; their territories in present-day US east of the Mississippi River; the Caribbean islands of Grenada, Dominica, St. Vincent and the Grenadines, and Tobago; Minorca in the Mediterranean; and Senegal in West Africa. They also formalized their cessation of the **Louisiana territory** to Spain. In exchange, Britain returned to France the valuable Caribbean sugar islands of Martinique and Guadeloupe; Belle Island, off the coast of Brittany; and the slave-trading island of Gorée in West Africa. France also regained its Indian factories, but they were not allowed to fortify them. The Spanish were forced to give their Florida territory to Britain, but in

exchange British troops left Havana and Manila. In Europe, France agreed to evacuate German territories.

Under the **Treaty of Hubertusburg**, the borders of 1756 were reinstated, so Austria retreated from Silesia and Prussia left Saxony, and Europe reverted to its former boundaries.

In the Ohio River valley territory, Pontiac (1720–69), a chief of the **Ottawa people**, was angered by the deal, which would put the land under British rule. In what became known as **Pontiac's Rebellion**, he led attacks against settlements, a situation that lasted until a deal between the Ottawa and British was reached in 1766.



Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, age 8, around the time he visited Britain.

IN AN ATTEMPT TO FILL THE COFFERS DEPLETED BY WAR, the British government brought in the **Sugar Act**, which clamped down on tax avoidance on imported molasses in North America, a move that angered traders and colonists.

At this time, the musical prodigy **Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart** (1756–91) was on a three-year tour of Europe with his family. He visited Munich, Brussels, Paris, and London, where his father Leopold presented him to play at the royal courts. While in London he met the German composer **Johann Christian Bach** (1735–82), who became an important musical mentor.



ENLIGHTENMENT IN EUROPE

The Enlightenment was a time of questioning many established beliefs in Europe—a change in ideas reflected in the writings and other cultural output from around the mid-18th century. It is also marked by scientific curiosity and advancement. This painting by Luke Howard (1772–1864) shows a fascination with weather that led him to classify and name many cloud types.

French philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–78) publishes *Du Contrat Social*

Earl of Sandwich creates famous snack of two slices of bread with meat in between

France and Spain sign Treaty of Fontainebleau

February 10 Treaty of Paris signed, ending Seven Years' War

February 15 Treaty of Hubertusburg signed, allowing Prussia to keep Silesia

Austrian musical prodigy Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart composes his first symphony

September 29 Sugar Act for British American colonies taxes molasses from non-British colonies

Jesuits expelled from French territories